to indicate to Trump that India was conscious of his concerns and was ready to partner with him and, as an expert put it, "to make good of the drought situation". That softened up Trump, but didn't deter him from piling up the pressure on India.

Four days before the Modi-Trump summit, the US deported 104 illegal Indian immigrants on a military aircraft. Photos of them in handcuffs and leg chains created an uproar in Parliament and put the government on the back foot. Then, just an hour before the meeting on February 13, Trump announced that he was imposing reciprocal tariffs on all nations that traded with the US. In the press conference, he even referred to India as being "right on top" of the list of abusers that had the highest tariff rates.

Trump's drastic move is likely to deliver a body blow to the WTO that in the 30 years of its existence had worked towards a fair rules-based trading system, even allowing Special and Differential Treatment (SDT) for developing countries to maintain higher tariffs if needed. "WTO is as good as dead now and we need to rethink our export strategy," says Sachin Chaturvedi, director general, Research and Information System for Developing Countries (RIS). The US interlocutors brushed aside these provisions as unfair in their talks with India and pointed out that in 2022, the average Indian tariff rate on US imports was 15.3 per cent, while the average US tariff on Indian imports was 3.83 per cent—an across the board 12 percentage point differential.

The Indian team was familiar with such pressure tactics and had factored in its response. Rather than focus purely on trade and tariffs, Modi wanted to use his summit meeting with Trump to dwell on a spectrum of forward-leaning issues that would set the agenda for the relationship for the next four years of his term and not just the coming four months. So, before the two leaders met, the Indian negotiators hammered out an agreement with Trump's team on four major pillars on which the new deal would rest. These were major commitments to enhance collaborations in trade, defence, energy and technology. The initiative was given a catchy name: the US-India COMPACT for the 21st Century, COMPACT being an acronym for Catalyzing Opportunities for Military Partnership,

FOR NEW DELHI, THE OTHER BIG GAIN WAS DEEPENING US COMMITMENT FOR A ROADMAP TO ACCELERATE AI INFRASTRUCTURE BY THE YEAR END WITH MILESTONES AND FUTURE ACTIONS



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ELON MUSK

THE MUSK FACTOR

The Tesla CEO, Trump's close associate, will look to launch his cars in the Indian market, now that the stumbling block of high import duties doesn't exist. But the road won't be smooth for either his EVs or Starlink, his satellite internet service

By **M.G. ARUN**

Elon Musk, 53, had shot to fame long before his public endorsement and funding of Donald Trump in the latter's second run for the White House. As the entrepreneurial spirit behind electric vehicle maker Tesla, space technology firm SpaceX and international telecom provider Starlink, Musk had garnered global spotlight